Srila Bhakti Sundar Govinda Dev-Goswami Maharaj

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Successor of Srila Sridhar Maharaj

Srila Bhakti Sundar Govinda Dev-Goswami Maharaj was the disciple, servant and successor of Srila Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar Deva Goswami Maharaj and the acharya of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math in Navadvip. The books of the Math style him His Divine Grace and Sevaite-President-Acharya — alongside the Founder-Acharya, Sridhar Maharaj; for short he is called Srila B. S. Govinda Dev-Goswami Maharaj or Srila Govinda Maharaj, and his Russian disciples call him Srila Gurudev and Acharyadev. In his youth, at his initiation, his guru gave him the name Gaurendu Brahmachari.

The whole life of Srila Sridhar Maharaj was an embodiment of sharanagati, surrender to the Lord, and in the Math his most generous gift is said to be the sharanagata-bhakta in whom that highest ideal became a living example — Srila Govinda Maharaj. Sripad B. B. Avadhut Maharaj called him “the precious gift of Srila Sridhar Maharaj to the whole world”. The book “Our Teachers”, in which the Russian mission of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math glorified “the greatest Vaishnavas of our time”, is dedicated to three teachers, and his name stands first in the dedication — before those of Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj and Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada. The aim of the book is “to give pleasure to our great guides and eternal well-wishers” and to help their followers unite their efforts in the service of the mission of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. Recordings of his lectures and talks are collected in an audio and video archive (govindamaharaj.ru).

Bamunpara: Family and Childhood

He appeared on 17 December 1929 in the village of Bamunpara, in the Burdwan district of West Bengal, not far from Navadvip, the place of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu’s appearance. By our calendar his appearance day is the Krishna-dvitiya of the month of Narayana[1]. The house where he was born stands next to the house where Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, the author of the “Sri Chaitanya-bhagavata”, lived.

For five generations his family had worshipped the Deities of Sri Radha and Sri Krishna; according to family tradition, They had been installed by Virachandra Prabhu himself, the son of Nityananda Prabhu. The boy grew up in an atmosphere of traditional Vaishnava culture, surrounded by the love of his relatives. His father was a well-known singer of Vaishnava songs, and from early childhood the son learned from him to lead kirtana. Even before the son’s birth, when the father visited a temple of Lord Shiva, it was revealed to him that the boy would be under the special protection of Lord Shiva and would become a great saint. “Thus from his very birth it was clear that Srila Govinda Maharaj was an extraordinary personality,” says “Our Teachers”, and the events of his life confirmed it again and again.

When he was thirteen his father left this world, and the care of the family fell on the young man’s shoulders. He began to work as a medical assistant in a clinic at Nandaghat, some fifteen kilometres from Bamunpara.

Navadvip: Gaurendu Brahmachari

In the spring of 1947, when he was seventeen, a sankirtana party from the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math came to Nandaghat. While the sadhus sang, the youth offered to accompany them on the mridanga. He was drawn to them, as “Our Teachers” puts it, by “some irresistible force”: he delighted in their company and loved to listen to their explanations of the “Bhagavata Purana”. At last he asked whether they would take him with them; the sadhus agreed, and at night he secretly left home and went with

them to Navadvip — just as Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami and Narottama Dasa Thakura had once left their homes for the service of Mahaprabhu. His coming to the Math took place, in the book's words, "after events in which the supreme will of Lord Krishna Himself revealed itself".

He came to the feet of Srila Sridhar Maharaj on the day of Nrisimha Chaturdashi. The guru at once paid him special attention and, as Srila Govinda Maharaj himself later recalled, asked him two questions: could he stay in the Math and dedicate his whole life to service — and would he follow the instructions of his spiritual master and not his own mind? Without a moment's hesitation the youth answered "yes" — and confirmed it with his whole life.

By a rule that Sridhar Maharaj himself had laid down in the Math, a newcomer passed a probation of at least six months before initiation. For this youth the guru broke his own rule: only a month later, at the festival of Ratha-yatra[2], he gave him diksha and the name Gaurendu Brahmachari, and only a week later introduced him to his godbrothers as his successor. Among them was Sripad Krishnadasa Babaji Maharaj; he accepted the youth as his own son and said to Sridhar Maharaj: "Please give special attention to Sri Gaurendu Brahmachari — he is very intelligent and has outstanding qualities." Recalling the early years of the Math, Sridhar Maharaj himself said: "Then came Sripad Govinda Maharaj, in his youth Sri Gaurendu Brahmachari."

Other disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura also spoke of the youth's extraordinary gifts — Sripad Bhakti Prajnana Keshava Maharaj, Sripad Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj, Sakhi Babu, Ram Gopal Babu, Sripad Madhava Maharaj, Sripad Jajabar Maharaj. Their words strengthened Sridhar Maharaj in his intention to make Gaurendu his successor and the acharya of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math. He drew him close as his personal servant and himself taught him the truths of the scriptures, Vaishnava etiquette and Sanskrit poetics — all that was needed to take up the responsibility for the spiritual guidance of the Rupanuga-sampradaya. For more than forty years Srila Govinda Maharaj remained his guru's trusted servant, carried out his most responsible commissions and was his personal physician. "I was beside Srila Guru Maharaj for about 42 years," he later said.

Sridhar Maharaj's choice surprised many: among his followers there were many serious and educated devotees, yet as the future acharya he named a very young, almost unknown youth. There was unrest in the Math, but Sridhar Maharaj firmly declared his decision and asked everyone who disagreed with him to leave the society; many sannyasis — his godbrothers — bore witness to this.

Thus Gaurendu entered a line of succession. How Srila Bhaktisiddhanta passed it on to Sridhar Maharaj he would later describe from the words of his guru and his guru's godbrothers: he himself came too late to see Srila Bhaktisiddhanta. On the eve of his departure Srila Bhaktisiddhanta called his closest disciples together and, not seeing Sridhar Maharaj among them, had him called. The disciples kept watch by the guru's bed two hours each, and Sridhar Maharaj chose the hardest hours — from two to four in the morning. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta asked him to sing "Sri Rupa-manjari-pada"; and when, in place of the abashed Sridhar Maharaj, a brahmachari with a beautiful voice began to sing, he stopped him: "I do not need beautiful singing — I want to hear this bhajan from Sridhar Maharaj." Having heard the song, he said: "I am happy." "From that moment all Guru Maharaj's godbrothers said many times — and I personally heard it from them: 'Before, we did not know how the transmission of authority takes place, but on that day we witnessed it. Srila Prabhupada transmitted the authority of the Rupanuga-sampradaya to Srila Sridhar Maharaj,'" Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled.

Calcutta: Beside Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami

For several years Sridhar Maharaj and the young Gaurendu lived in Calcutta, on Sitakanta Banerjee Lane, in a preaching centre on the upper floor of the pharmaceutical laboratory of Abhay Charan De —

the future Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada. According to Srila Govinda Maharaj himself, at Swami Maharaj's request the Calcutta branch of the Math was housed in his home for many years[3]; the Swami often came to them and spoke at length with Sridhar Maharaj.

When leaving Calcutta, Sridhar Maharaj told his disciple to study the "Bhagavad-gita" under Swami Maharaj, who at once discerned unusual spiritual qualities in the youth. The guru often took Gaurendu with him to preach, and he also preached by himself in the Bara Bazar, going from stall to stall — only he had no books to give out at that time.

What he came to distribute was the Swami's journal. The Swami had brought out two or three issues of "Back to Godhead", but lacked the means to continue it, and in his room lay huge stacks of journals that no one undertook to distribute. "Take the journal and distribute it, going from door to door," the Swami said to the youth. "So I became the first distributor of that journal," Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled. Many years later he added: "I did not know a word of English, but I was very proud of the chance to distribute that journal," and admitted that today he was prouder of it still.

Those were troubled times. They lived among Hindus, and the Muslim houses began right next door; clashes flared up nearby again and again, and at night bandits attacked peaceful homes. "It was very frightening; I had never seen anything like it," Srila Govinda Maharaj related. Once the alarmed Swami said to him: "Gaurendu — at that time my name was Gaurendu Brahmachari — I have a stock of bottles with incendiary mixture in the attic. If we are attacked, take the bottles and throw them at the attackers." But by the Lord's mercy it all passed.

Preaching did not come easily to the Swami. He was then a grihastha, a family man, and Gaurendu a brahmachari in saffron robes, and at public lectures the Swami would yield the vyasasana to him: he taught him a few shlokas of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" and said: "Read these verses… and then I will explain them to the audience." "His desire to spread Krishna consciousness was enormous," Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled.

The Swami loved the youth with a father's love. Four years of preaching together bound them with ties of love and tenderness; the Swami himself taught him the Vaishnava scriptures and the mridanga and cared for his health and well-being. He himself loved food cooked in ghee and scolded the youth: "Why do you eat dry rice, without ghee?! Be sure to eat it with ghee!" — but Gaurendu could not afford ghee: his usual breakfast was one paisa's worth of rice.

Srila Govinda Maharaj also recalled how the Swami said to his sister Bhavini Didi — she was also called Pishima: "'Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam' is a very necessary and wonderful book. You have money. Please help to publish this book." And it was she who gave the money for the first edition of this book by Sridhar Maharaj.

"He Will Make Your Name Glorious"

A pro-rector of Calcutta University who had witnessed a two-hour debate in which Gaurendu took part said to Sridhar Maharaj: "Pay attention to this youth. He will make your name glorious. I know what I am saying: I am a pro-rector and deal with thousands of graduates."

Once Sridhar Maharaj had promised to open with a lecture on the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" a memorial gathering in the house of the Calcutta businessman Sri Satkari Banerjee, whose father, Sri Hari Prasad Banerjee, had left this world. But the guru had a severe attack of migraine, and he sent in his place Gaurendu, who was then twenty-one. The host was alarmed: how would this youth speak on the "Bhagavatam" before so many educated people? But Gaurendu amazed everyone by the depth of his understanding and gave an exhaustive answer to every question. The next morning Satkari Banerjee told Sridhar Maharaj that the listeners — among them at least eight doctors of philosophy — had been

satisfied in the highest degree: "'This boy has satisfied our intellectual hunger,' they said." It was Satkari Banerjee who later paid all the expenses of the installation of the Deities at the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math.

At the school from which Gaurendu had graduated he was invited to give a lecture on the "Srimad-Bhagavatam"; the whole staff of the school, headed by the principal, came to hear their former pupil. The teachers began to test him with questions — and were astonished at his answers. Such a change, they unanimously decided, could be explained only by the exceptional mercy of the Lord, which had come through the blessings of his spiritual master.

In Chaitanyapur, at a zamindar's house, they were expecting Sridhar Maharaj himself, and the youth was received with displeasure. "Ask him your questions, and it will become clear to you what an exalted position Maharaj himself holds," said the devotee accompanying him. There were a great many questions about Vaishnavism, and Gaurendu asked the gathering to choose someone to speak on their behalf, and began himself with a short introduction: "So, there are five levels of jnani-scholars: pratyaksha, paroksha, aparoksha, adhokshaja and aprakrita." Having explained each of them, he asked the listeners to which they reckoned themselves to belong — and all the questions resolved themselves.

Sridhar Maharaj spoke of his disciple with love: "Many times I have seen that his advice helped me in the most varied situations… Certainly he has siddhis. This is my firm and sincere conviction: he possesses supernatural abilities, though outwardly this is not always evident." And again: "He never saw our Guru Maharaj, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, yet there is so much in common in their convictions, as if they had associated many times. Much has been given to him."

The Strength of a Young Cobra

A zamindar said to Sridhar Maharaj: "You sent me a brahmachari, young, but at the same time very competent, tejasvi (very powerful). He appeared like a little cobra…" Srila Govinda Maharaj later explained these words: the venom of a young cobra is no weaker than that of a grown one, and even a little cobra can kill an elephant.

Nor was he timid before his guru's godbrothers. Once he asked a sannyasi reputed to be a great pandit: "Can God commit suicide?" The sannyasi was displeased and put him off: "One should not ask such questions," — and finally retorted: "You are still a child; what can you know at all?" Then the youth recited a Sanskrit verse whose meaning is "Even a cobra's baby has a deadly bite!"[4] and answered his own question: "Yes, God can commit suicide. He commits suicide in Brahman, His impersonal aspect, the brahmajyoti, in which the infinitesimal particles of Bhagavan, the jivas, lose their individuality." This answer is not about the Lord Himself, Who eternally remains a Person and is subject to no annihilation: it is a sharp image directed against impersonalism. The impersonal effulgence of Brahman, in which the impersonalists seek "liberation", extinguishes the individuality of the jivas, the tiny particles of Bhagavan, and such merging is tantamount to self-annihilation. Sridhar Maharaj often recalled this story, but added that such a question should not be asked.

He knew his guru's godbrothers so well that he could guess the course of their thoughts. Once he was accompanying Sripad Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj and his disciples. Noticing that rain was gathering, Gaurendu asked one of the senior disciples whether he knew which verse his guru would speak on that day — and, hearing that no one but Goswami Maharaj himself could know, recited a shloka saying that truly gloomy is the day that passes without the nectar of talks about Achyuta, not the day that is overcast with clouds. And so it turned out: Goswami Maharaj began his lecture with that very verse. Gaurendu knew his nature and understood that in bad weather he would want to cheer up his downcast listeners.

The Heart of a Vaishnava

His special spiritual position was revealed in his deeds more than once. In Vrindavan, in the Imlitala temple built by Sripad Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj — in its courtyard grows the imli tree under which Mahaprabhu sat — Sanskrit verses by Sridhar Maharaj are carved in marble about the exact time of Mahaprabhu's coming to Vrindavan and about His lila there. Sridhar Maharaj conveyed the date, as is customary in Sanskrit prosody, by number-words: "veda", for example, may mean three or four, depending on how many parts the Vedas are counted to have. The date itself is usually considered unknown: the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita" and other books contain only hints of it. His guru's godbrothers could not decipher the verse, and then the young Gaurendu said, "I know what this means," and named the date. It was objected that Srila Bhaktisiddhanta had given a different one. "Maybe, but what my Guru Maharaj says is true, and I can prove it," he replied, and proved it, citing one quotation after another from the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita". And when Sripad Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj, the builder of that temple, himself worshipped Sridhar Maharaj on his appearance day during the Vraja-parikrama, Gaurendu recorded his words on tape: a lion, going forward, looks back — and so we, while preaching, look back to learn what Sridhar Maharaj thinks of our preaching.

He always showed respect to Vaishnavas and had a wonderful gift for bringing everything around him into harmony. Once, setting out on pilgrimage to Vrindavan with his disciples, Sridhar Maharaj met at the railway station Sripad Bhakti Pradipa Tirtha Maharaj with his disciples. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta had called Tirtha Maharaj "Prabhupada-shreshtha" and had verses in his honour carved on a marble wall of the Bagbazar Math in Calcutta; but relations between the two sannyasis were not very close at the time, and the youth was troubled that he could not show Tirtha Maharaj due respect. "Tirtha Maharaj is here. I feel I should offer him my respects. Will you allow me to do so?" he asked his guru. "Yes, of course," Sridhar Maharaj replied. Gaurendu bowed to Tirtha Maharaj, talked with him and his disciples, and the tension dissolved. "This youth possesses genuinely Vaishnava qualities," said Tirtha Maharaj.

More than once he had to settle disagreements. "There are so many fine qualities in you, and we are very sorry that you are not in our Math," Sripad Madhava Maharaj told him on one such occasion. And Sripad Jajabar Maharaj confessed: "You are a worthy representative of Sridhar Maharaj. I like everything you do: whatever you take up, you succeed in. No one but you is able to keep track of everything at once."

He had a deep knowledge of the scriptures, philosophy, Sanskrit grammar and prosody, and assemblies of pandits more than once honoured him with the highest titles. Sridhar Maharaj discussed his compositions with him, and, as "Our Teachers" says, "great merit in their creation belongs to Srila Govinda Maharaj": a master of alankara, Sanskrit poetics, he would suggest to his guru variants of the shlokas he was working on. Some of these shlokas were never published, and many were never even written down — they could be learned only from him: he remembered them and explained their meaning superbly.

Ram Gopal Babu — a senior disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, formerly a manager, a Master of Arts of Calcutta University, zamindar of the Sampal district and a great Sanskrit scholar — completed under Sridhar Maharaj's guidance his work on the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu". Reading at that time a Sanskrit poem by the young Gaurendu, he embraced him in admiration: "How beautiful is what you have written! You are very young, but already so skilled in composing verses in Sanskrit!" But when he was given to read a poem by his godbrother, a Master of Arts, he only exclaimed: "Why are you giving it to me?" — while of Govinda Maharaj's poems he always spoke with the greatest respect.

"This youth will become a great saint and will deliver thousands of souls," Sridhar Maharaj once foretold.

Swami Maharaj's Letters and Mayapur

Having arrived in America, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami wrote his first letter from there to Srila Govinda Maharaj: "My dear Sripad Govinda Maharaj"[5]. The Swami had received two copies of the journal "Gaudiya Darshan", which Sridhar Maharaj's Math had begun to publish — back in Mathura Sripad Keshava Maharaj had told him that Sridhar Maharaj intended to bring it out — and was extremely glad. "I know that everything that happens in the Math becomes possible only thanks to your energy. Now I understand why Sripad Sridhar Maharaj has bestowed all his mercy upon you. He far-sightedly noticed your hidden abilities for future service," he wrote.

The Swami particularly liked the article "Chhalar Pathe": it was not only beautifully written but also deep; dry philosophical arguments attract few readers today, while such articles are read gladly. "From this article I understood that you really have an outstanding talent, and in time you will probably become the greatest transcendental humorist in the history of journalism." And further: "For me you will forever remain one of my most beloved sons. I will always keep in my heart a fatherly affection for you." In the same letter the Swami quoted lines from his letter to Sripad Goswami Maharaj: "The beginning is beyond all praise… He has an excellent assistant in young Govinda Maharaj, and I think this is a very fortunate choice."

Later, anxious about his health, the Swami wrote to him again: "I feel that my time is coming to an end, I shall soon die, and I would like to leave my body in Vrindavan. And therefore please ask Srila Sridhar Maharaj what I should do: should I go to Vrindavan or remain in the Western world?" Govinda Maharaj passed the question on to his guru, and Sridhar Maharaj dictated the reply to him: "Wherever you are, there is Vrindavan. Krishna is always with you and will always come to your help. And if it falls to you to leave your body in New York, it will mean that Vrindavan has come to you in New York; do not doubt it."

When Sridhar Maharaj visited the Swami in Mayapur, at the Chandrodaya Mandir, Govinda Maharaj — "his beloved disciple", as "Our Teachers" calls him — invariably accompanied his guru. On 17 March 1973, at the opening of that temple, the Swami and Sridhar Maharaj sat on one vyasasana, while Govinda Maharaj spoke into the microphone — so a photograph has preserved them. His guru had asked him to speak: he was unwell and could not give a long speech. Govinda Maharaj began with a verse of Raghupati Upadhyaya, which Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami also quotes:

kaṁ prati kathayitum īśe samprati ko vā pratītim āyātu go-pati-tanayā-kuñje gopa-vadhūṭī-viṭaṁ brahma

"To whom shall I tell it, and who will believe me, that the Supreme Absolute Truth is the beloved of the young cowherd girls in the groves by the Yamuna?" (CC, Madhya 19.98)

He applied this verse to the Swami himself: "Who will believe me that Srila Swami Maharaj, whom we knew earlier as Abhay Babu, a regular participant in the programmes of the Sri Gaudiya Math and a householder occupied with family cares and business affairs, has now become a world acharya and is known everywhere? He has spread Krishna consciousness all over the planet, accomplishing the most impossible of all impossible deeds."

Sridhar Maharaj recalled that Govinda Maharaj then called Srila Bhaktisiddhanta an extraordinary personality through whom Mahaprabhu wished to preach His teaching: out of many worthy followers he chose Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami for preaching in the West, and the Swami accomplished the task splendidly; the Swami accepts Sridhar Maharaj as his shiksha-guru, and regards Govinda Maharaj himself as a son. The Swami confirmed: "All that Govinda Maharaj has said is true. I love him as my own son, and his Gurudeva, Sridhar Maharaj, I consider my shiksha-guru." Thus, before many

godbrothers and thousands of devotees, he publicly called Govinda Maharaj his dear son.

“Srila Swami Maharaj is the greatest Vaishnava, and when he publicly declared, ‘Govinda Maharaj is my son,’ these were not mere words. At that time he was a Guru of world stature. For me this is a great mercy and a rare fortune,” Srila Govinda Maharaj said.

Sannyasa and the Transfer of Authority

For forty years Sridhar Maharaj prepared his beloved disciple for the service of acharya, and all that time he urged him to accept sannyasa. “He would say, ‘After you accept sannyasa, I will hand over all my duties to you.’ To this I replied, ‘I am not ready. I do not feel worthy to become a sannyasi. Please give me time,’” Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled. By 1964 he was still not a sannyasi, and this greatly grieved his guru. For twenty more years his guru asked him, and each time he thought: if I accept sannyasa, Guru Maharaj will soon leave this world — for only the mission, the Deities and the devotees of the Math keep him here. He knew that his guru wished to lay upon him the duties of acharya.

In 1985 Sridhar Maharaj called him to his room: “The day after tomorrow you will accept sannyasa.” The disciple asked for three months to settle his affairs and proposed to take sannyasa at Gaura-purnima, but the guru replied: “No, you will accept sannyasa the day after tomorrow, otherwise I shall die today.” Knowing that his guru had a weak heart, he did not dare refuse: “I am like a sacrificial animal, with whom you are free to do as you see fit. This time I cannot refuse you.” The guru invited Sripad Puri Maharaj, and two days later, when he arrived, Srila Govinda Maharaj accepted sannyasa. This was on 6 November 1985, on Bahulashtami — the Krishna-ashtami of the month of Damodara, the day our calendar observes as the day of his sannyasa.

The next morning was Sridhar Maharaj’s own appearance day. Early in the morning Sripad B. A. Sagar Maharaj came to him: “Srila Guru Maharaj, yesterday you gave sannyasa to Srila Govinda Maharaj, but I think he accepted sannyasa many, many lifetimes ago.” “You mean that this was done only to show people his true position, but in fact he has held it for a long time?” the guru replied, and, sitting in his chair, smiling and laughing, spoke about his disciple for two or three hours. “It was the appearance day of the Guru himself, but the Guru was performing kirtana to his disciple!” Sagar Maharaj recalled. At his Vyasa-puja Sridhar Maharaj glorified Srila Govinda Maharaj for more than three hours: his deep understanding of the scriptures, his ability to bring everything into harmony, his exalted devotional nature, his serious and responsible approach to every task.

On Gaura-purnima 1986 — 26 March — Sridhar Maharaj proclaimed him acharya of the mission, handed over to him all his authority and, boundlessly happy, himself seated him in his own acharya’s chair[6].

Srila Govinda Maharaj himself did not seek such a position — he, as “Our Teachers” says, always strove to take the humblest position. But Sridhar Maharaj was happy to reveal to his disciples and to all seekers of truth his innermost desire to see him as his successor, and he wished to manifest his true greatness. In his will he briefly explained why he had chosen precisely him as acharya of the Math. From Gaura-purnima 1986 until his departure on 12 August 1988 he no longer accepted disciples, and when Govinda Maharaj was away from the Math, he himself gave initiation — in his disciple’s name. “Can one find in history such an unsurpassed example of such inconceivable relations between teacher and disciple?” asks “Our Teachers”.

Once Sridhar Maharaj said to him: “I consider your spiritual position higher than mine. There is something in you so extraordinary that I do not find it in anyone else.” “You think so?” the disciple asked again. “Yes, and for many reasons. I have often found that your advice and suggestions are very valuable to me. Before, it was so only with Vasudeva Prabhu. In any case, I often have the feeling that

you are more qualified than I. I have not had such a feeling in dealing either with my disciples or even with my godbrothers…"

To show the exalted position of his disciple and for the benefit of his followers, Sridhar Maharaj himself composed a pranama-mantra for him, himself glorified him, and ordered his picture to be placed on the temple altar for daily worship. "Srila Govinda Maharaj is a paramahamsa by his very nature," he often said, and, never once showing displeasure with his disciple, he glorified his qualities again and again. Here is that mantra:

gurvābhīṣṭa-supūrakaṁ guru-gaṇair āśīṣa-sambhūṣitaṁ cintyācintya-samasta-veda-nipuṇaṁ śrī-rūpa-panthānugam govindābhidham ujjvalaṁ vara-tanuṁ bhakty-anvitaṁ sundaraṁ vande viśva-guruñ ca divya-bhagavat-premṇo hi bīja-pradam

"I bow to him who perfectly fulfils the innermost desires of his guru, who is adorned with the blessings of the whole guru-varga, who is versed in all the Vedas — in the conceivable and the inconceivable — and follows the path of Sri Rupa; to him who is called Govinda, radiant, beautiful of form, full of devotion — the teacher of the world, the giver of the seed of divine love for the Lord."[7]

"This is an unprecedented case in the history of the sampradaya, when the teacher worships his disciple," says Sripad B. B. Avadhut Maharaj: in this mantra Sridhar Maharaj proclaims that his disciple "satisfies the innermost desires of his spiritual master", "has received all the blessings of his guru-varga" and "is able to give the seed of love for God to all sincere souls".

The Guru's Last Years

There was a time when Sridhar Maharaj, citing his advanced age, decided to accept no disciples at all. He began to initiate people from the West only after his beloved disciple vowed to him to take care of the Deities, the mission and all the devotees.

Sridhar Maharaj taught that a disciple's relationship with his Gurudeva is not limited to dasya-rasa, the service of a servant to his master: it can also be friendly, and at times it is coloured even by a parental feeling with which the disciple surrounds his guru with care and attention. "Our Teachers" gives these words of his when telling of the most intimate side of the relationship between the guru and Srila Govinda Maharaj.

Sripad Bhakti Sudhir Goswami Maharaj recalled Sridhar Maharaj's words: "In fact, in many respects Srila Govinda Maharaj is more qualified than I. If you associate closely with him, you will understand what level this personality is on." Shortly before his departure, seeing Goswami Maharaj off to the West, the guru called him to his bedside, took him firmly by the shoulders and said: "Goswami Maharaj, this may be my last instruction to you... My sincere and ardent desire is — help Govinda Maharaj. Do you promise?" — "Yes, Maharaj," he replied in a voice trembling with emotion.

Sripad Shrutashrava Prabhu visited the Math while Sridhar Maharaj was still present, and with every visit he discovered more exalted qualities in Srila Govinda Maharaj: "What amazed me especially was the love he felt for his Gurudeva, and which his Gurudeva had for him." On his first visit, at Gaura-purnima, Govinda Maharaj sang verses of the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" to his guru to please him. Shrutashrava saw Sridhar Maharaj for the last time in June 1988: he had by then withdrawn completely, and hardly anyone was admitted to him except his closest servant, Srila Govinda Maharaj; it was by his mercy that Shrutashrava was let in for a last darshan. "Most wonderful of all was to see how Srila Sridhar Maharaj was transformed when Srila Govinda Maharaj entered the room and sat beside him. Guru Maharaj embraced Srila Govinda Maharaj with one arm, and in the other hand he held his palm."

Having handed over the post of acharya to his disciple, Sridhar Maharaj withdrew into his room and spent the last years of his manifest pastimes in deep experience of divine separation from the Lord. On 12 August 1988 he entered the eternal pastimes.

Acharya of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math

In 1989, on Sridhar Maharaj's appearance day, Srila B. K. Tapasvi Maharaj addressed the devotees gathered at the Math: "Srila Sridhar Maharaj was an outstanding follower of our Gurudeva, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Goswami Maharaj, and he chose Srila Govinda Maharaj as his successor. Therefore, my dear devotees, please accept him as the successor of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, or else your spiritual life will come to ruin." This was said by the very Tapasvi Maharaj who had once recommended Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta for two initiations on one day — harinama and gayatri-diksha.

Other eminent godbrothers of Sridhar Maharaj also blessed Srila Govinda Maharaj — Sripad B. V. Jajabar Maharaj, Sripad B. D. Madhava Maharaj, Sripad Krishnadasa Babaji Maharaj, Sripad B. P. Puri Maharaj, Sripad B. K. Shanta Maharaj and Sripad Satprasangananda Prabhu — thereby confirming his position as a "true acharya".

Srila Govinda Maharaj accepted the mercy of his guru and the Vaishnavas as seva — an opportunity to serve Sri Sri Guru-Gauranga and the devotees. Under his caring guidance the Math grew rapidly. It had been revealed to Sridhar Maharaj that the lake by the Math is Govinda-kunda — the very one in Vrindavan, manifest also in Navadvip; and now on its banks rose the main temple of the Math, a temple of Shiva, the Nat-mandir, the Chandan-yatra-mandir, residences for the devotees and other buildings. The lands of the Math expanded considerably, and extensive farming is carried on there.

Through his efforts temples and centres were founded in Vrindavan, Jagannatha Puri, Calcutta and other cities of India, and his disciples opened centres all over the world.

He also explained the emblem of the Math printed in the present edition of Srila Sridhar Maharaj's book "Sri Guru and His Grace": "Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, where sankirtan is always going on, is inside Krishna's flute, and the sound om, which is the very gist meaning of gayatri, comes from Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, radiating merciful rays." For, as Srila Sridhar Maharaj explained, *gāyatrī muralīṣṭa-kīrtana-dhanaṁ rādhā-padaṁ dhīmahi* — "Krishna's flute does not make any other sound except for the glorification of Srimati Radharani." "The position of the guru is like water," writes Srila Govinda Maharaj; "the servitors of Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math are like lotuses; and the Supreme Personality of Godhead, worshipped in His divine form of Radha-Krishna (om), is the sun": if there is no water — "if one cannot take shelter of Sri Guru and His grace" — the lotus is burnt by the rays of the sun. The English translation of the shloka Sridhar Maharaj composed about the Math was likewise made from his Bengali translation. In the list of the Math's publications eleven English books stand under his name — among them "Divine Servitor", "Divine Guidance", "Golden Reflections", "Affectionate Guidance", "Nectarean Glories of Sri Nityananda Prabhu", "Religion of the Heart" and "Revealed Truth".

All over the World

Fulfilling the will of his guru, in 1992 Srila Govinda Maharaj began to preach worldwide. At first devotees simply invited him to visit their centres and ashrams, but already the first journey showed what success awaited his mission. His English improved right in the course of his lectures — Sripad Sagar Maharaj or someone else among his companions would prompt him how to render Bengali concepts — but his spiritual qualities and knowledge of the science of devotion very soon won the hearts of many sincere people. Through him and through these devotees people in more than forty countries came to

know the life and teaching of Srila Sridhar Maharaj.

Thus the saying arose: “The sun never sets on the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math” — for there is no country, large or small, without a branch of the Math and loving disciples serving Srila Govinda Maharaj.

In 2007 Sripad B. B. Avadhut Maharaj said that thanks to the preaching of Srila Govinda Maharaj, “who has travelled all over the world many times”, centres and followers of the Math had appeared in almost every country, and that thousands of disciples had received from him initiation into the chanting of the Holy Name and the path of pure bhakti. “He has already visited Russia ten times,” he added.

Everywhere he spoke of Krishna consciousness without partiality. Once in Santa Cruz he was asked how to unite “two camps” — ISKCON and the followers of Srila Sridhar Maharaj; of his answer, below.

Russia

Srila Govinda Maharaj gave special attention to Russia. In 1994, in America, a Russian devotee asked him for initiation — Jagannatha Vallabha Prabhu, the future Sripad Bhakti Bimal Avadhut Maharaj. “I gave him initiation and said: ‘You are a Russian and run a successful business in America, but I would like you to return to Russia, do business there and develop the preaching,’” Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled.

In 1995 he sent to Russia one of his first Russian disciples, Jagannatha Vallabha Prabhu, and his close companion Sripad Sagar Maharaj. That same year Srila Sridhar Maharaj’s book “Sri Guru and His Grace” appeared in Russian for the first time, and Sagar Maharaj gave initiation to those who wished on behalf of Srila Govinda Maharaj. Thus the preaching of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math in Russia began.

The following year Jagannatha Vallabha Prabhu organised the first Vaishnava festival with his participation. In his first lecture in Russia Srila Govinda Maharaj spoke of the spiritual kinship of Russians and Indians: “Having come here, I was very surprised to see that Vaishnavism lives naturally in the hearts of Russian people.” Humility, tolerance and respect for others, without which there is no Vaishnava, he said he had found here in everyone. “Now Russian people are absorbing spiritual experience, but in the future Russia herself will make a priceless contribution to the spiritual treasury of the whole world.”

During the world tour of 2003 he said that Russia had always supported India and that their cultures are similar, and when they merge into one, it will be a spiritual culture. “Not a single country is atheistic,” he said then: India is known for its spiritual culture, but that culture is here in Russia too. “Now the doors are thrown open, and we come here to embrace this country. There is only one nationality — that of a resident of the transcendental world. And we are all children of that world; we must not forget it.”

From then on he came to Russia almost every year, accepting as disciples tens and hundreds of sincere people. Over ten years, under the guidance of Sripad Avadhut Maharaj, the leader of the Russian mission, a cultural centre opened in Moscow and a temple was built in Saint Petersburg: Srila Govinda Maharaj himself made its sketch, and Vijay Raman Prabhu directed the construction. In 2000 the Deities of Sri Sri Guru Gauranga Radha-Madhava-Sundarjiu were installed in the temple. Disciples of Srila Govinda Maharaj appeared in many cities of central Russia, Siberia, Karelia, the Far East, Ukraine, Latvia, Abkhazia, Georgia, Moldova and Belarus.

To three Russian disciples — Sripad Bhakti Bimal Avadhut Maharaj, Sripad Bhakti Chaitanya Bharati Maharaj and Sripad Bhakti Achintya Madhava Maharaj — he gave sannyasa. Every year preachers of

the Math came to Russia — Sripad B. S. Goswami Maharaj, Sripad B. P. Siddhanti Maharaj, Sripad B. L. Akinchan Maharaj, Sripad B. K. Giri Maharaj, Sripad Shrutashrava Prabhu and others — and twice a year Russian devotees went on pilgrimage to Navadvip: for the Vyasa-puja, the appearance day of Srila Govinda Maharaj, and for Gaura-purnima.

On 26 October 2006, the day of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami's departure, Srila Govinda Maharaj lectured in Saint Petersburg, at Lakhta. He had seen in the temple a map of Russia marking the cities with centres of the Math, and was amazed at how widely the preaching had spread: the country, formerly communist, had become "theistic, 'Krishna conscious'". "In Russia our Mission shines like the sun," he said; without Krishna's will this would have been impossible, and what would come next he did not venture to guess. "In spite of my poor health I have come here to see the faces of the Russian devotees. In my mind I embrace all who are present. You are extremely dear to me. Your devotion has called me here." And the Deities of the Petersburg temple, Sri Sri Guru Gauranga Radha-Madhava-Sundarjiu, in his words, "have given me everything; They have given me the opportunity to preach in Russia", and by Their mercy the Russian devotees are growing spiritually.

There he also spoke of Sripad Avadhut Maharaj: he invites other preachers to Russia — Sripad Goswami Maharaj, Sripad Janardana Maharaj, Sripad Siddhanti Maharaj, Sripad Akinchan Maharaj, Sripad Bhagavat Maharaj, Sripad Paramahamsa Maharaj, Sripad Shrutashrava Prabhu and many others — but never takes any credit to himself. "Sometimes I even scold him for it. I tell him: 'How can you act like this? You live in such austere conditions, hold no position, eat poorly and take no care of yourself at all.'" How he manages to preach so successfully, Srila Govinda Maharaj admitted, he could not understand. But it was not done, he said, by Avadhut Maharaj, nor by himself, nor by Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, nor by Srila Guru Maharaj: "In truth it was done by Krishna Himself — He used us as an instrument to carry the Holy Name 'from door to door' — into every home, to every person."

The book "Our Teachers" was completed in 2007, during the twenty-third world preaching tour of Srila Govinda Maharaj. In spite of his advanced age, poor health and the prohibitions of his doctors, he came to Russia, preached with inspiration, sang bhajans and gave initiation to new disciples. On leaving he said: "If Lord Krishna prolongs my days, I shall certainly come to Russia."

Teachings

The whole meaning of Vaishnava sannyasa, Srila Govinda Maharaj said, is to serve twenty-four hours a day the feet of Sri Sri Guru-Gauranga, the Holy Name, the Deities and the devotees. The spiritual path, he repeated, requires freedom from envy, humility, respect for the Vaishnavas and purity in chanting the Holy Name. To everyone who came into contact with him he strove to give the most precious thing — pure, selfless devotion, that rasa for the sake of which the Rupanuga-sampradaya exists and preaches.

The preaching of recent decades he called a spiritual revolution. "Thanks to the preaching of Srila Swami Maharaj, Krishna consciousness, like a huge wave, has swept over the whole world. Now a new wave has come — the preaching of Srila Sridhar Maharaj." Thus Mahaprabhu's prediction was fulfilled: "In every town and village throughout the world My holy name will be chanted" (CB, Antya 4.126). "This miracle has happened, and it is impossible to believe it!" He recalled that Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura preached although the sahajiyas, fearing to lose their influence, wanted to destroy his mission and even tried to kill him; he opened sixty-four centres in India and sent disciples to the West. The teachings of Buddha and Shankara took a long time to be accepted, but Srila Swami Maharaj presented Krishna consciousness to the whole world in a few years — "in how swiftly this is happening there is, undoubtedly, something supernatural".

“I do not notice the faults of devotees,” he said: all that they do in the West and in the East he considered wonderful, remembering the mood of Swami Maharaj and of his guru. Mistakes happen, “but that is not terrible”; there are many acharyas in the world, and perhaps not all of them are perfect, but they labour like a farmer who digs, sows and waters before he reaps a harvest. In war, he said, losses are inevitable — not only soldiers perish, but also civilians, women and children. “Our preaching also resembles a war, a war with maya, with Durga. It is a real uprising”: Srila Swami Maharaj, Srila Guru Maharaj and others created a revolutionary atmosphere, someone was wounded or killed, but “the gates of Durga-devi’s prison are destroyed… The revolution has taken place, the gates are torn down, and the prisoners are running to Vaikuntha.” The war here is an image: maya is the external energy of the Lord, and Durga-devi, His faithful servant, by His will keeps the souls who have turned away from Him in the prison of this world; the preachers’ “uprising” is the liberation of the prisoners by the Holy Name, which the Lord Himself desires.

The worldwide preaching of the Math he considered possible only by the mercy of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, who, in Srila Sridhar Maharaj’s words, “cut a tunnel through the mountain of the Western ego”: the success in Russia is his merit, and the movement of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, spread over the world, “has sprouted from the seed planted by Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada”. On the day of the Swami’s departure, when the devotees had cooked his favourite dishes, Govinda Maharaj said that “all the glory” of the preaching in the West had come by his mercy, and recalled his life: his father’s house stood on Hazen Road, in a prestigious district, and in the first half of his life he was a successful businessman — Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi came to his Allahabad centre to make purchases. But Krishna wished that for the sake of Krishna-sankirtana he should become a pauper — and “his ‘simple living’ is not the same as what is usually meant by simplicity”. On that day the Swami is glorified in all the Maths — in Navadvip, in America, Mexico, England; the devotees of ISKCON, “members of our family”, celebrate him too, and the sankirtana movement he began in the West “will never stop”.

ISKCON, he said, is a society that truly spreads Krishna consciousness; the Swami founded it for the highest good of conditioned souls and in only five years helped seekers attain the highest goal — selfless devotion to Krishna. “Srila Swami Maharaj is a shaktyavesha-avatara. An ordinary man could not have created such a Mission in only five years,” he repeated the words of his guru. News that people all over the world were chanting the maha-mantra greatly gladdened Sridhar Maharaj, and he always glorified the Swami, while the Swami often came to tell him about his preaching. As leaders the Swami appointed the GBC, the Governing Body Commission, and was very proud of them; Govinda Maharaj warmly recalled his meetings with Sripad Bhavananda Maharaj, Sripad Tamal Krishna Maharaj, Sripad Achyutananda Maharaj and others: “I have many friends in ISKCON who have a deep understanding of the ideas of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. They practise and preach Krishna consciousness, and I respect them very much.”

Might his disciples distribute the books of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami? He saw no obstacle to it, if the BBT publishing house agreed — for he himself had been “probably the first” to distribute “Back to Godhead”: “I think that everyone who honours Srila Sridhar Maharaj and Srila Swami Maharaj will be happy to see their books side by side.” And to one whose friends were dissuading him from reading Sridhar Maharaj’s books he recalled the closeness of the two acharyas — his own forty-two years beside his guru, the Calcutta branch of the Math in the Swami’s house, the “Gita” studied under the Swami: “To the very last days of his stay in this world Srila Swami Maharaj wanted Srila Guru Maharaj to head ISKCON.” And Sridhar Maharaj founded his Math “to help sincere seekers of truth”, not wishing to disturb other missions.

In Santa Cruz, answering the question about the two camps, he said: “I have not come here for sectarian propaganda. I live in the mood of my guides. The association of my Gurus was free.” Both — Srila Sridhar Maharaj and Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj — are his Gurus: “Srila Sridhar Maharaj is my diksha- and shiksha-guru. Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj, by the mercy of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, is also my shiksha-guru.” He had the good fortune to learn from many others as well, but these two are his principal guides, and the line is from Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura. “I have no party attachments”: it does not matter who belongs to which party, or who lives in India and who in America — “I do not look for differences”; he preached Krishna consciousness rather than sorting out who, in his view, deserves trust.

Without humility, patience and respect for others, he taught, spiritual progress is impossible: this path Mahaprabhu showed in the third verse of the “Shikshashtaka”:

“One should constantly chant the Holy Name of Krishna, feeling oneself humbler than a blade of grass and more tolerant than a tree, showing due respect to others and not desiring respect for oneself.” (CC, Adi 17.31)

These qualities protect one from vaishnava-aparadha — the greatest obstacle to chanting the maha-mantra. “Through the Vaishnavas the maha-mantra descends into the material world from the higher plane of existence. It spreads in this world through the Pancha-tattva — Sri Krishna Chaitanya, Nityananda Prabhu, Sri Advaita, Sri Gadadhara and Srivasa Thakura. But if we offend Them, the Holy Name will not reveal Itself to us.” Mahaprabhu taught that one should avoid vaishnava-aparadha and the other nine offences against the Holy Name.

The meaning of life, he said, is to attain Krishna consciousness, the most vital need of every jiva. It does not matter whether you are a disciple of Srila Sridhar Maharaj or of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj, whether you were initiated in ISKCON or in the Math; what matters is to practise under the guidance of a true Vaishnava — one who has these three qualities and genuine knowledge of Sri Krishna. The goal of life is sadhu-sanga, association with the sadhu, and the sadhu makes no distinction between camps and parties: he sees only levels of devotion. “In everyone I would like to see a friend and well-wisher. I feel respect for everyone. I am afraid to offend a Vaishnava, to whatever sampradaya he may belong.”

“There is no problem with ISKCON,” he said; to one in whom the party spirit is strong he advised giving up such thinking and chanting the maha-mantra given by Srila Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar Deva Goswami Maharaj and Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj. “They did not intend to create sects — why should we do so? To bring harmony into the relations between these societies is not at all difficult.”

“What do I live for? Why have I come here?” he asked himself, and answered: if he brings benefit to others, his efforts are not in vain; otherwise it is only a waste of money earned by the devotees. He travelled the world to meet friends and talk with them about Krishna consciousness, and tried to preach without partiality. “Even if it is one person, I shall be immensely happy. Then I shall know that I have fulfilled my mission.”

Such was his guru too. Sridhar Maharaj always tried to bring everything around him into harmony, and members of the Gaudiya Mission and even representatives of groups hostile to him came to him for advice. Once Sridhar Maharaj asked the leader of one of them: “Why do you come to me, if our views are so different?” — and heard: “Maharaj, you belong to no party… Conversing with you, I feel genuine happiness.”

“I am a disciple of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, and from my youth I adopted his attitude to the world. In everyone I see a friend, and if a person has no friendly feelings towards me, I try to win him over. I would not like to have enemies.” He had many friends in ISKCON and in the societies founded by his

guru's godbrothers and by his own: "Their mercy sustains my life," he said; when it touched him, obstacles left his spiritual path. Therefore, following the instructions of his guru, he tried to live in harmony with everything around him.

Anyone sincere who longed for spiritual life could become a disciple of Srila Govinda Maharaj. The chief principle of his sampradaya is "mercy is higher than justice": Mahaprabhu distributed mercy to all, regardless of outward differences. The freedom of the soul, he taught, is above all, for it is Krishna's priceless gift; spiritual life is above all an inner path, and each must walk it himself, relying on the mercy of Guru, Sri Krishna and the Vaishnavas. And among the chief principles proclaimed by Sri Chaitanya is "compassion for every soul, chanting of the Holy Name and service to the Vaishnavas".

The book "Our Teachers" appeared in his lifetime and says nothing of his departure. Srila Govinda Maharaj left this world and entered the eternal pastimes of the Lord on 27 March 2010, at 4:25 in the morning, in Kolkata. The Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math honours this day on the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Vishnu[8].

In the chart of the disciplic succession printed in "Sri Guru and His Grace", Srila Sridhar Maharaj is followed by Srila Govinda Maharaj, and he by Srila B. N. Acharya Maharaj — Srila Bhakti Nirmal Acharya Maharaj, his successor as President-Acharya of the Math, in whose service the electronic edition of the book was prepared in 2023 — and then by Srila B. T. Niriha Maharaj.

After the departure of Srila Govinda Maharaj, according to the mission, Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math was headed by a board of acharyas. It comprised disciples of Srila Govinda Maharaj — Srila Bhakti Nirmal Acharya Maharaj, Srila Bhakti Bimal Avadhut Maharaj, acharya of the Russian mission, and Srila Bhakti Vijay Trivikram Maharaj — as well as disciples of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, Srila Bhakti Pavan Janardan Maharaj and Srila Bhakti Kusum Ashram Maharaj.

1. The date and place of his appearance are given in "Our Teachers". By calculation, at sunrise on 17 December 1929 the Krishna-pratipad was still running, and the dvitiya began in the afternoon; the book does not give the hour of his birth.

2. So — "only a month later" — in "Our Teachers" (and in the article on Srila Sridhar Maharaj). By calculation, Nrisimha Chaturdashi in 1947 fell on 3 May and Ratha-yatra on 19 June, that is, about a month and a half later.

3. "Our Teachers" speaks of this in different ways: in one place it says that Sridhar Maharaj and the young Gaurendu lived there "for several years", in another Srila Govinda Maharaj recalls that the Calcutta branch of the Math was housed in the Swami's home "for ten years".

4. This verse and the shloka about the gloomy day (below) are given in "Our Teachers" in a Sanskrit transliteration that appears to be corrupt (in the last line of the second verse the negative *na*, "not", has evidently dropped out); their sources are not named. Here only their meaning is given, as the book conveys it.

5. So — "My dear Sripad Govinda Maharaj", "in young Govinda Maharaj" — the Swami's letters address and name him in "Our Teachers", although he accepted sannyasa only in 1985. When Gaurendu Brahmachari came to be called Govinda the book does not say; nor does it give the year of the letter. Here we follow the book.

6. In Srila Govinda Maharaj's recollection given in "Our Teachers" it is said that he accepted sannyasa in 1985 and was proclaimed acharya "two months later, at Gaura-purnima"; the same book says that Sridhar Maharaj seated him in his chair and "on the next day" glorified him at his Vyasa-puja. By the recollection of B. A. Sagar Maharaj, Sridhar Maharaj's appearance day fell on the day after the sannyasa, and by our calendar the day of the sannyasa is the Bahulashtami of the month of Damodara, the eve of that festival; in 1985 this was 6 November. The next Gaura-purnima fell on 26 March 1986 — four and a half months later; from "that day of Gaura-purnima 1986", according to the same book, Sridhar Maharaj ceased to accept disciples. Hence here: sannyasa on 6 November 1985, proclamation as acharya on Gaura-purnima 1986 (so also in the article on Srila Sridhar Maharaj).

7. In the Sanskrit of the mantra his name is woven into its very praise: *govindābhidham* — "called Govinda", *bhakty-anvitaṁ sundaraṁ* — "full of devotion, beautiful"; compare "Bhakti Sundar Govinda". In the translation given in "Our Teachers" the full name is stated outright.

8. "Our Teachers" was completed in 2007, in his lifetime, and does not speak of his departure. The day of remembrance follows our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math): the festival in honour of the day of his departure falls on the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Vishnu. The year, hour and place of his departure were supplied by the mission (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, 2026); by our calendar 27 March 2010 is the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Vishnu.